and therefore my work station was at Phek. Whenever the CO moved out for operations or reconnaissance missions it was my task to accompany him, and look into the coordination aspects. Besides, the IO generally functioned as an understudy to the adjutant of the battalion, and as per the normal practice, took over that appointment in due course.

It was on one of these reconnaissance missions that I accompanied Lieutenant Colonel Wadke to the Indo-Burmese border area, about ten kilometres ahead of one of our company posts at Khanjangkuki. The trek to the top of the mountain was one of the most fascinating climbs of my life. We walked along a foot track from Khanjangkuki to the border along the Patkai mountain range. This area was known as the Somra Tract and had a very dense rainforest cover. I had never seen forests like that before. There were tall trees with a canopy branching out on the top and with very little undergrowth. One could not see the soil as the ground was covered by a soft and moist carpet of dead leaves and decaying branches of fallen trees which had lichen and fungi all over. All of a sudden my eyes fell on a ground orchid in full bloom.

This was the first time I had ever seen orchids in the wild. It was a stunningly beautiful sight. We bivouacked for the night in this area and returned the next day to Jessami, the road head. From there we drove back to the Battalion HQ at Phek. The CO did not share with me the reason for this reconnaissance trip. The track we followed had witnessed the Japanese cross the Chindwin river and advance to Kohima during the Second World War. After their defeat in the Battle of Kohima, the British Indian Army under General (later Field Marshal) W.J. (Bill) Slim chased the Japanese back over the Patkai range into Burma.

While we were camping in the forest, we received a wireless message that a vacancy for the intelligence course had been allotted to the unit, and the name of the officer detailed to undergo the course had to be communicated to the Brigade HQ without delay. I was able to prevail upon the CO and get a decision in my favour. As I was functioning as the IO of the battalion, I felt it would be appropriate if I was nominated for it. This decision of Lieutenant